DISCUSSION PAPER

Artist Directory

Should We Build It? What Should It Look Like?

Juergen & Scott · April 2026

5 Research Investigations | 200+ Citations | Idea 001

THE ORIGINAL PROPOSAL

Scott's Pitch

> *"Create a private, exclusive, curated online artist gallery/directory powered by our database featuring 1000+ artists anyone can view, discover and connect with artists for a nominal fee."*

SUBSCRIBERS

1,000

@ $25/mo ($250/yr)

ARTISTS

1,000

@ $10/mo ($100/yr)

PROJECTED REVENUE

$350K

annual target

The data asset: 1,000+ artists and 8,000+ artworks with AI-enriched profiles, classifications, tags, and dimensions

RESEARCH APPROACH

How We Investigated This

5	200+	15+
parallel deep-research investigations	web citations analyzed	art platforms and competitors benchmarked

Investigation 1 — Market viability: do paid artist directories work?

Investigation 2 — Freemium models: what to show, what to gate

Investigation 3 — Market validation: how to test before building

Investigation 4 — Artist value proposition: what artists actually need

Investigation 5 — B2B opportunity: who would pay real money?

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Five Key Findings

1. Scott's specific revenue model faces strong headwinds. No successful art platform charges consumers to browse. At 1,000 artists, the database is too small to justify a subscription.

2. The underlying idea has real merit — with a different structure. Freemium with gated connection features aligns with every successful platform's approach.

3. The strongest revenue opportunity is B2B. Interior designers and art consultants would pay $300-500/month. Real budgets, real pain points.

4. Exhibition auto-matching is a greenfield opportunity. No platform does AI-powered matching of artists to open calls. The enriched data already exists for this.

5. Even if revenue never materializes, it's a lead generation engine — driving submissions, segmented contacts, grant applications, and ecosystem growth.

MARKET REALITY

Browsing Is Free

Every major art platform offers free discovery

Platform	Who Pays	Pricing	Browse
Artsy	Galleries: $200-3K+/mo	Subscriptions + commissions	FREE
Saatchi Art	Artists: 40% commission	Pure commission	FREE
Singulart	Artists: 45-50% commission	Commission + tiers	FREE
Artnet	Data subscribers: ~$29+/mo	Data + advertising	FREE
Artwork Archive	Artists: $6-139/mo	SaaS for artists	NONE

What IS paywalled successfully: market data and analytics (Artnet, ArtFacts) — intelligence *about* art, not access to *view* art. Beowolff Capital acquired Artnet for ~$73.7M and took a controlling stake in Artsy in 2025 — consolidation is around data + marketplace, not directories.

REVENUE REALITY CHECK

Scott's $350K vs. What's Realistic

Scenario	Year 1	Year 2	Assumptions
Scott's Projection	**$350K**	$350K+	1,000 subs + 1,000 artists
Optimistic Freemium	**$50-80K**	$200-300K	B2B + artist pro, aggressive growth
Realistic Freemium	**$18-40K**	$80-150K	Modest conversion, organic growth
Lead Gen Only	**$0**	$0	Value via submissions, grants, partners

The honest framing: Even Artsy (3.5M registered users, $200M+ in funding) took years to launch a $14.99/mo tier. The $350K figure requires 1,000 paying subscribers — two orders of magnitude beyond typical conversion from a 1,000-artist base.

THE MODEL THAT WORKS

Gate Connection, Not Content

Show the art freely. Charge for contact and tools.

Tier	Price	What's Included
Public Browse	Free	All artworks, basic search, artist names, truncated bios
Free Account	Free (email)	5 wishlists, follow 20 artists, full bios
Collector Premium	$9.99/mo	Direct messaging, unlimited saves, price alerts, advanced filters
Artist Free	Free	Profile + uploads, basic analytics, receive inquiries
Artist Pro	$19.99/mo	Exhibition matching, lead CRM, advanced analytics, SEO
Institutional	$299/mo	Database access, bulk search, API, multi-user

Key insight: Direct messaging/artist contact is the #1 conversion driver — 50-65% of paying users cite it as primary reason to subscribe.

ARTIST ECONOMICS

What Artists Actually Spend

$30-100/month fragmented across 4+ tools

PORTFOLIO HOSTING
$8-26
Format, Cargo, Squarespace

SUBMISSIONS
$17-42
CaFE, Submittable fees

SOCIAL MEDIA
$5-43
Buffer, Later, freelancers

INVENTORY
$9-42
Artwork Archive

The consolidation opportunity: Artists pay $200-500+/year on submission fees alone — with zero matching intelligence. 40% feel unconfident in self-promotion. A platform that consolidates discovery, analytics, and exhibition matching replaces multiple tools.

THE REAL OPPORTUNITY

B2B: Interior Designers & Art Consultants

WILLINGNESS TO PAY

$300-500

per month

GLOBAL MARKET

$128B

interior design services

US DESIGN FIRMS

10-15K

with sufficient scale

⚠ The pain point: When a designer needs 12 paintings at 36"x48" with specific color palettes for a hotel corridor, they spend 20-30 hours manually browsing with no multi-dimensional filtering. Our data has exactly what they need: dimensions, medium, subject, tags — searchable attributes no other emerging-artist platform offers.

B2B SEGMENTS

Ranked by Fit and Revenue Potential

#	Segment	Pain Point	Asset Fit	Annual Rev
1	Interior designers + consultants	Manual sourcing is painful	STRONG	$150-350K
2	Small-to-mid galleries	Oversupply, not undersupply	STRONG	$80-200K
3	Independent curators	Finding artists for themed shows	STRONG	$40-100K
4	Corporate art programs	Buy through intermediaries	MEDIUM	$45-100K
5	Arts education	Rigid budgets, long cycles	STRONG	$100-300K (3+ yr)

COMPETITIVE POSITIONING

What Nobody Else Combines

AI-Enriched Discovery

Not just portfolio dumps — AI-researched profiles, validated citations, classified artworks

Multi-Dimensional Search

Dimensions, medium, subject, tags, color — visual attributes no other emerging-artist platform offers

Emerging/Mid-Career Focus

Existing platforms skew established. This serves the underserved middle of the market.

501(c)(3) Trust Factor

Grant eligibility, tax advantages, "built to serve artists, not extract from them"

THE FLOOR CASE

Even If Nobody Pays

The platform has substantial value as a lead generation engine

Exhibition Submissions

Every browser who sees "Submit to our next exhibition" is a warm lead for NRA, Artsville, and partners

Segmented Contacts

Artist vs. curator vs. collector — transforms an undifferentiated list into a multi-purpose asset

Grant Leverage

5,000+ users strengthens every NEA, Knight Foundation, and Bloomberg application

B2B ARTS CPL

$300-500 per lead

SEGMENTED LIST VALUE

$2-5K per year

GRANT APPLICATION LIFT

$10-100K NEA alone

GROWTH MILESTONES

What Success Looks Like

Month 3

500+ registered users · clear segment breakdown · engagement data to prioritize features

Month 6

50+ paying users across tiers · 2-3 institutional/B2B customers · measurable lift in exhibition submissions

Month 12

200+ paying users · $3-5K MRR · 2,000+ registered users · at least one grant citing platform data

Month 18+

$8-15K MRR · 5,000+ registered users · B2B pipeline generating $50K+ ARR

OPPORTUNITIES BEYOND DISCOVERY

Exhibition Auto-Matching

The headline feature nobody else offers

0
platforms that do
AI-powered open call matching

75%
acceptance rate for
early submitters (vs. 60% late)

58→79%
acceptance rate for
repeat submitters (4-10 subs)

How It Works (B2C)

AI matches artist profiles to open calls based on medium, style, tags, location, career stage. The enriched data already exists in the system. Artists currently spend $200-500+/year on submission fees with zero matching intelligence — CaFE and Submittable host calls but don't match. This feature alone justifies Artist Pro at $15-20/mo.

Average artist spends 3-10 hours/year on repetitive submission data entry. Auto-matching eliminates this entirely.

THE DATA GAP

Why Matching Needs Interviews

Public research can't capture what matters most for matching

What We Have Today

FROM PUBLIC RESEARCH (PERPLEXITY)

Bio, exhibition history, medium, style, education, gallery representation, social media presence, press mentions

What Matching Actually Needs

FROM CONVERSATIONAL AI INTERVIEW

Venue preferences, shipping willingness, submission fee budget, geographic constraints, career ambitions, preferred exhibition scale, medium they *want* to be known for

The key insight: The AI interview isn't just a nicer onboarding experience — it's critical infrastructure for the matching engine. Preference data, intent data, and constraint data can't be scraped from the web. A 10-15 minute conversation during onboarding captures what no competitor can replicate with public research alone. This is the data moat.

THE B2B PLAY

Open Call Matching for Galleries

Not just artists — galleries and organizations as clients

8-12K
active open calls globally at any time

5,700+
call listings on CaFE alone annually

0
competitors offering roster-based matching

Gallery Subscription

Gallery uploads roster of 20-50 artists. Platform scans 10,000+ calls and surfaces matches by medium, style, geography, career stage. Gallery offers this as a value-added service to their artists.

Arts Orgs & Collectives

Arts councils (200-2,000 members), cooperatives, university art departments, nonprofit galleries. Matching as a member benefit across local → regional → national → international.

No one connects these two sides. CaFE, Submittable, ArtCall = submission infrastructure. ArtLogic, ARTERNAL = gallery CRM. Neither bridges the gap. Pricing: $99-299/mo per gallery. 500 subscribers at $149/mo avg = $894K ARR. Adjacent: ArtLogic charges $409-$1,690/mo for gallery CRM alone.

AI-POWERED INTERVIEWS

Conversational AI as Platform Infrastructure

COMPLETION RATE

70-90% AI interview

10-30% traditional form

RESPONSE DEPTH

2.5-8x longer than forms

COST PER INTERVIEW

$1-1.50 via Retell.ai

Use cases across the platform:

Artist onboarding — 10-15 min audio interview replaces forms, captures artistic philosophy, influences, career stage, exhibition goals. AI summarizes into structured Supabase fields.

Pricing validation — Conversational Van Westendorp study yields more honest responses than surveys.

B2B qualification — AI pre-filters high-value design/consultant prospects before human engagement.

Collector engagement — Preference discovery via dialogue, not checkboxes.

PHASED ROLLOUT

AI Interview Implementation Path

Phase 1

WEEKS 1-6 · $200-500

TheySaid or User Intuition for pricing study + smoke test interviews

Phase 2

MONTHS 3-6 · $5-10K

Custom Retell.ai / Vapi.ai build for artist onboarding interviews

Phase 3

MONTHS 6-12

B2B qualification interviews with Ribbon AI

Phase 4

YEAR 2+

Hume AI emotional analysis layer for deeper artist profiling

Key insight: AI interviews aren't a separate product — they improve activities the platform already needs to do. The 90-day experiment calls for onboarding questions, a Van Westendorp survey, and 15-20 qualitative interviews. Conversational AI delivers higher quality at lower effort and cost for all three.

VALIDATION STRATEGY

The $600 Smoke Test

Test before you build. 2-3 weeks.

8-12%
CTR
Strong product-market fit. Build the paid version.

2-8%
CTR
Proceed with caution. May work with iteration.

<2%
CTR
Rethink the model. Keep as lead magnet.

The 90-day experiment: Launch simple public gallery (weeks 1-2) → Gate contact behind signup (weeks 2-3) → Monitor engagement (weeks 3-4) → AI-powered Van Westendorp pricing study (weeks 4-5) → Smoke test with $300-600 ad spend (weeks 5-6) → Segment analysis (weeks 6-8) → AI qualitative interviews (weeks 8-9) → Synthesize and decide (weeks 9-12)

Day 90 decision: Signup >15% + any segment shows WTP of $5+/mo in both survey AND smoke test = build paid version. Strong engagement but weak WTP = keep as lead magnet. Signup <10%, time on site <2 min = rethink.

DISCUSSION

Questions for Us

Is this a platform play or a feature of the existing ecosystem? Does it live on its own or enhance Arterial/NRA/Artsville?

Do we build for artists (the supply side) or for the people who buy from them (the demand side)? Where does the first dollar come from?

If open call matching is the killer feature — should the directory be the product, or should the matching engine be the product with the directory as the data layer?

What's the minimum viable test? Can we validate willingness to pay before writing a single line of code?